Draft - expert review pending

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Understanding Critical Thinking

Before you can teach pupils to think critically, it helps to be clear about what critical thinking actually is - and, just as importantly, what it is not. In everyday staffroom talk the phrase is sometimes used to mean "being sceptical about everything" or "finding fault with what other people say". This unit uses a different meaning, the one the course guide follows: critical thinking is the habit of judging a piece of reasoning against a set of clear standards. It is a skill you can train, not a personality you either have or lack.

Unit learning outcomes

By the end of this unit you will be able to:

1. Explain what critical thinking is and distinguish it from merely criticising or from general scepticism.
2. Name and apply the recognised standards used to judge a piece of reasoning.
3. Identify the common barriers that stop people - including teachers - from thinking critically.
4. Distinguish a statement, a claim, an issue and an argument, and recognise when a piece of text is making an argument.

5. Analyse a described teacher's reasoning against the standards and name the barrier it shows.

Prerequisite knowledge

None beyond HSC-level general study skills. This is the opening unit of the course. No prior logic or philosophy is assumed, and none is needed. If you have ever had to decide whether a colleague's argument was convincing and why, you already have the experience this unit builds on.

In this unit

1. What thinking is, and what makes it critical - the functions of thought and the idea of critical thinking.
2. The standards, and what they are for - the standards applied to reasoning and why they matter.
3. What gets in the way - the barriers that stop critical thinking.
4. Statements, claims, issues and arguments - the basic units reasoning is built from.
5. The critical thinker, and the teacher as one - the characteristics of a critical thinker, applied to teachers.

How to use this unit

Each topic is one learning cycle. Start with the classroom situation, work through the explanation, and try the activity before you move on. The "Check your understanding" items are there to help you retrieve what you have learned - have a go at them without looking back, then check your

answer. The unit ends with a summative assessment that draws the five topics together.

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